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Containers, vessels

5.18 Containers, vessels

References:

Hebrew אָסוּךְ (’asuk) 2KI 4:2

Hebrew בַּקְבֻּק (baqbuq) 1KI 14:3, JER 19:1, JER 19:10

Hebrew חֶרֶשׂ (cheres) PRO 26:23

Hebrew כְּלִי (kli) GEN 42:25, GEN 43:11, GEN 45:20, EXO 37:16, LEV 6:21, LEV 6:21, LEV 11:32, LEV 11:33, LEV 11:34, LEV 14:5, LEV 14:50, LEV 15:12, LEV 15:12, NUM 4:9, NUM 5:17, NUM 19:15, NUM 19:17, DEU 23:25, RUT 2:9, 1SA 9:7, 2SA 17:28, 1KI 10:21, 1KI 17:10, 2KI 4:3, 2KI 4:3, 2KI 4:4, 2KI 4:6, 2KI 4:6, 2KI 4:6, 2CH 9:20, EST 1:7, EST 1:7, EST 1:7, JOB 28:17, PSA 2:9, ISA 22:24, ISA 22:24, ISA 22:24, ISA 65:4, ISA 66:20, JER 14:3, JER 18:4, JER 18:4, JER 19:11, JER 22:28, JER 32:14, JER 40:10, JER 48:11, JER 48:11, JER 48:12, JER 48:38, JER 51:34, EZK 4:9

Hebrew עֶצֶב (‘etsev) JER 22:28

Greek ἀγγεῖον (aggeion) MAT 25:4, JDT 7:20, JDT 10:5, SIR 21:14, 1MA 6:53

Greek ἄγγος (aggos) MAT 13:48

Greek ἄντλημα (antlēma) JHN 4:11

Greek κάλπη (kalpē) 4MA 3:12

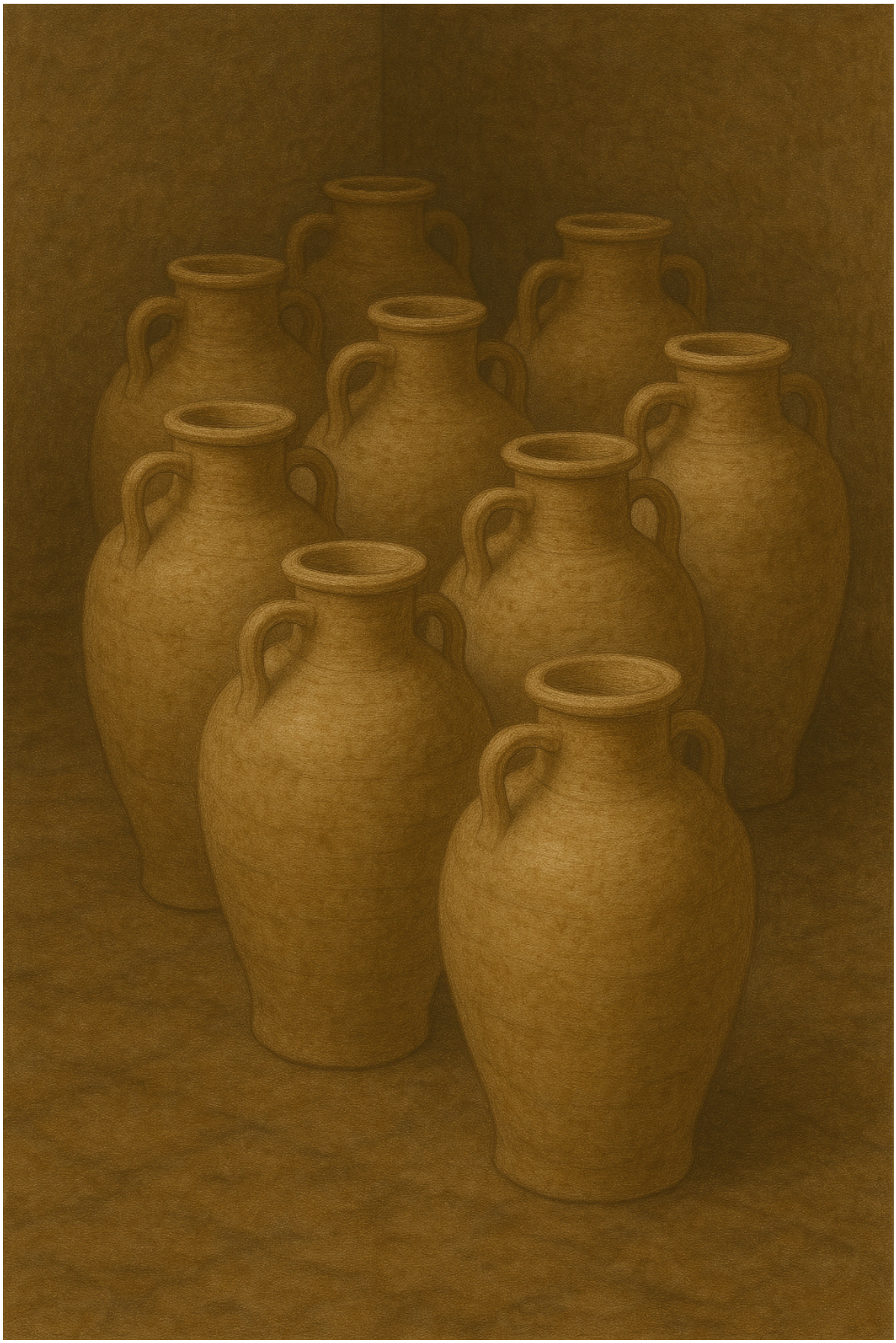
Greek καψάκης (kapsakēs) JDT 10:5

Greek σκεῦος (skeuos) LUK 8:16, JHN 19:29, ROM 9:21, REV 2:27, LJE 1:15

Latin vas 2ES 6:56, 2ES 9:34

Description and usage:

Description and usage:



(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The container was a solid object for holding things. Containers were made of earthenware or metal, sometimes of wood. They varied widely in size and shape.

Translation:

Flask (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, MMA)Most languages have a generic term for containers. The Hebrew word kli is extremely general, similar in its usage to English words like “implement,” “instrument,” or even “object” or “thing.” Translators should be guided by the context. In RUT 2:9, for example, it is obvious that the reference is to vessels from which the workers can get a drink of water, and the translator may want to indicate this; for example, GNT, NIV and CEV have “water jars,” and NCV says “water jugs.” In most passages a general word will be the right choice. Translators should avoid words that indicate containers made of plastic, rubber, tin, or any other materials that were not known in biblical times.

The Hebrew word ’asuk in 2KI 4:2 refers to some kind of jar or flask, probably made of earthenware. Most translations add the qualifier “small” (GNT, CEV).

The Hebrew word baqbuq refers to a small flask with a narrow neck. In modern Hebrew it is the word for “bottle.”

In PRO 26:23 the Hebrew word cheres refers to a vessel that is made from cheap and commonplace material.

JOB 28:17: At the end of this verse the Hebrew is literally “a vessel of fine gold.” While most translations have something like “jewels of fine gold” (RSV), GNT and others understand “vessel” (kli in Hebrew) to refer to a “gold vase,” which is probably more accurate than “jewels.” In some languages “a vessel of fine gold” may be rendered “a pot made of fine gold.” Since the focus is on the high value of wisdom, rather than on a comparison with any particular implement, translators may want to follow CEV for the whole verse: “Nothing is its equal—not gold or costly glass.”

The vessels referred to in MAT 25:4 would have been relatively small, containing not more than a liter (about a quart).

The containers in MAT 13:48 would have been rather large, containing perhaps 15–19 liters (4–5 gallons).

JHN 4:11: The Samaritan woman observes that Jesus has “nothing to pull up water with.” The Greek word antlēmaJHN 4:11 comes from a verb meaning “to draw water.” It gives no indication of its shape or of the material from which it was made. Many translations say “bucket.” This may imply a container made of metal, plastic or even rubber, which are all inappropriate. Even a bucket made of wood was probably unlikely in New Testament times. It was more likely a container made of leather. In many languages the best solution will be to avoid using a word for a specific object. An acceptable solution would be to begin the woman’s words in this verse with “Sir, the well is deep, but you have nothing to pull up water with.” A similar rendering is employed by GW, NCV, NIV, SPCL, PV, and others.

JHN 19:29: While RSV and GNT render the Greek word skeuos as “bowl,” others have “jar” (CEV, NIV, NLT, REB). Here it is best to use a generic term such as “vessel” or “container” (GECL). The word skeuos is used often in the New Testament with the broad meaning of “thing, object, stuff” (see MAT 12:29; MRK 3:27; MRK 11:16; LUK 17:31; ACT 10:11; ACT 10:16; ACT 11:5; ACT 27:17; 2TI 2:20; 2TI 2:21; HEB 9:21; REV 18:12; REV 18:12).

Containers for storage

5.18.1 Containers for storage

Storage jars were containers of varying size used for holding and storing liquids such as water and oil or dry foods such as grains. These containers were generally carved out of soft stone or were made from clay. They were more or less cylindrical in shape with an opening at the top. The opening could be closed with a lid (see 5.18.1.2.1 Lid, cover<REALIA:5.18.1.2.1>).

Stone jar

5.18.1.1 Stone jar

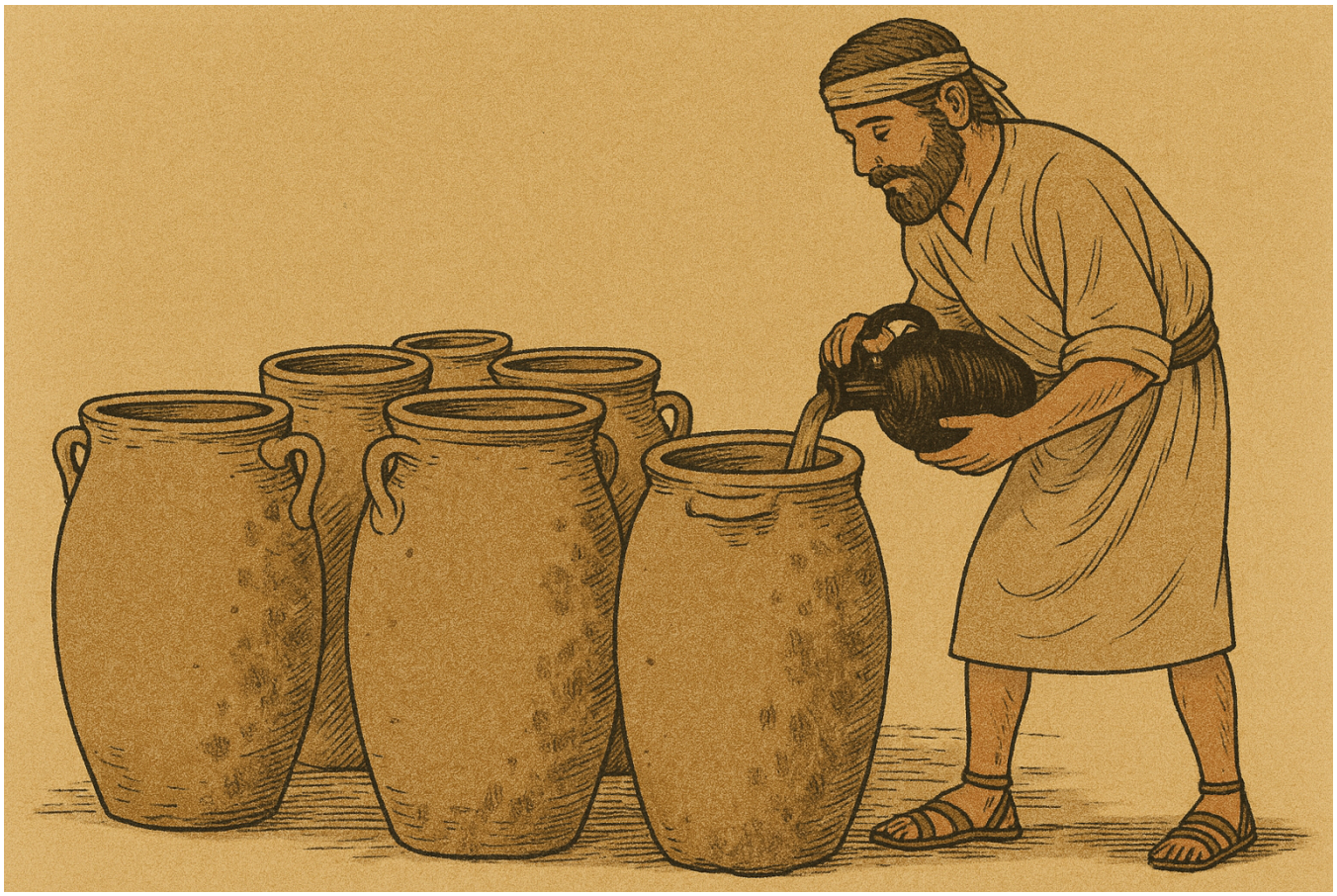
Reference:

Greek λίθινος, ὑδρία ((lithinos) hudria) JHN 2:6, JHN 2:6, JHN 2:7

Description and usage:

Mycenean stone storage jar, Late Bronze Age, 1570–1200 BCE (© Zde, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)Stone jars were water containers. In the only place in the Bible where these water containers are mentioned, they are described in unusual detail. Their capacity is given as “between twenty and thirty gallons” (GNT; about 80–120 liters), and they are said to be made of stone. Stoneware in Bible times was made from soft stone. It could be carved with a hammer and chisel and made smooth with various tools, or it could be turned on a lathe much like wood was turned by a carpenter.

Translation:



(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)For the water containers in RUT 2:9, see the discussion at 5.18 Containers, vessels<REALIA:5.18>.

JHN 2:6: The fact that the jars here are stone, rather than earthenware, is important. According to Jewish law, earthenware jars, if contaminated, had to be broken, but contaminated stone jars could simply be washed. The Greek word hudria indicates that the jars were intended for water. The relation between the words in the phrase “six stone water jars” (GNT) must be made more explicit in some languages, for example, “six large jars made of stone and used for holding water.”

Clay jar

5.18.1.2 Clay jar

References:

Hebrew כַּד (kad) GEN 24:14, GEN 24:15, GEN 24:16, GEN 24:17, GEN 24:18, GEN 24:20, GEN 24:43, GEN 24:45, GEN 24:46, JDG 7:16, JDG 7:16, JDG 7:19, JDG 7:20, 1KI 17:12, 1KI 17:14, 1KI 17:16, 1KI 18:34, ECC 12:6

Hebrew נֵבֶל (nevel) ISA 30:14, LAM 4:2

Hebrew צַפַּחַת (tsapachath) 1SA 26:12, 1SA 26:16, 1KI 17:12, 1KI 17:14, 1KI 17:16, 1KI 19:6

Greek κεράμιον (keramion) MRK 14:13, LUK 22:10

Greek ὑδρία (hudria) JHN 4:28

Description and usage:

Description and usage:

(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The clay jar was an earthenware vessel that was used as a storage container for liquids like wine and olive oil (see also 5.18.1 Containers for storage<REALIA:5.18.1>). It could also be used to carry water and other liquids.

Translation:

Unlike stone water jars (see 5.18.1.1 Stone jar<REALIA:5.18.1.1>), which were intended only for the storage of water, clay jars had to be light enough when full to be carried by a woman, who normally did such work in the society of that time. While John uses the same Greek word for “jar” in 2.6 and in 4.28, it is clear from the context that two different kinds of vessels are intended. The woman in JHN 4:28 would not have been carrying a stone jar, which would have been very heavy. Most translations have “water jar” (RSV, GNT). Where a language makes a distinction between a vessel for drawing or carrying water and a vessel for drinking, a word for the former vessel should be used.

Lid, cover

5.18.1.2.1 Lid, cover

Reference:

Hebrew צָמִיד (tsamid) NUM 19:15

Description:

Storage jar with lid (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, MMA)The lid was a cover made to fit tightly over the opening of a pot or jar. In some cases the lid was secured by tying it to the container.

Translation:

The Hebrew word tsamid normally means a kind of bracelet worn as jewelry (see 10.5.2 Bracelet, armlet, anklet<REALIA:10.5.2>). In NUM 19:15, however, it indicates the way a jar was covered. The translation of this verse should convey the idea that the vessel is not closed or covered and so foreign objects might fall into it. Possible models are GNT “Every jar and pot in the tent that has no lid on it also becomes unclean” and NCV “And every open jar or pot without a cover becomes unclean.” In this verse the Hebrew word pathil, which describes the situation of the lid relative to the vessel, is expressed by some translations as “tied” (NASB, REB, Luther, ITCL). Others choose a more general term, such as “fastened” (RSV, NRSV, NIV). Another model for the whole verse is “Any jar or pot that is not closed tightly becomes unclean.”

Potsherd

5.18.1.2.2 Potsherd

References:

Hebrew חֶרֶשׂ (cheres) JOB 2:8, JOB 41:22, PSA 22:16, ISA 30:14, EZK 23:34

Greek ὄστρακον (ostrakon) SIR 22:9

Description:

Pieces of broken pottery (© Davidbena, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The potsherd was a piece of pottery that had broken. Since it resulted from breaking, it had no regular shape. Potsherds were usually not very large, smaller than the palm of a hand, and they could have sharp edges.

Translation:

Most household vessels for eating, drinking, cooking, and so on were made of clay, either sun-dried or fired. Such vessels broke easily and were not usually repaired. Pieces of such broken vessels were extremely common. Most translations render “potsherd” as “piece of broken pottery” (GNT, NIV, NCV) or something similar.

Alabaster jar, alabaster flask

5.18.1.3 Alabaster jar, alabaster flask

References:

Greek ἀλάβαστρον, ἀλάβαστρος (alabastron, alabastros) MAT 26:7, MRK 14:3, MRK 14:3, LUK 7:37

Description and usage:

Description and usage:

Alabaster ointment pot (Egypt, 2000–100 BCE) (© Wellcome Images, UK, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The alabaster jar was a jar made of calcite stone. This jar normally had a rather long neck that had to be broken off for the contents to be used. It served primarily as a container for precious substances such as perfumes. Such jars were usually small.

Translation:

Archaeological and literary evidence reveals that in the Hellenistic period jars for perfume, originally of alabaster, were replaced by glass jars. But these continued to be called “alabasters.” They were sealed when purchased and were opened by breaking. This is why MRK 14:3 very properly says that the woman broke the jar, a detail not recorded in the Matthew parallel. While glass was not as expensive as alabaster, it too was not commonplace and was a valued commodity.

When rendering “alabaster jar,” many translators have used a term meaning “jar” or “flask” along with a descriptive qualifier, such as “made of alabaster stone,” “made of valuable stone,” or “made of valuable stone called alabaster.” Since alabaster is not widely known today, some translations omit this information; for example, for the literal phrase “an alabaster flask of ointment of pure nard, very costly” (RSV) in MRK 14:3, CEV says “a very expensive bottle of sweet-smelling perfume”; this, however, leaves the reader in doubt as to whether the bottle was expensive or its contents (it was the contents). GECL and the Hebrew common language version are better with “a small bottle with pure, expensive nard oil.”

Money box, treasure box

5.18.1.4 Money box, treasure box

References:

Greek γλωσσόκομον (glōssokomon) JHN 12:6, JHN 13:29

Greek θησαυρός (thēsauros) MAT 2:11, MAT 12:35, MAT 12:35, MAT 13:52, LUK 6:45

Greek κιβωτός (kibōtos) 1ES 1:51

Description and usage:

(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The money box was a container, perhaps made of wood, in which money or other small valuable objects were kept. The box would probably have been small enough to be carried easily in one hand or under the arm.

Translation:

“Treasure box” may be rendered “box with valuable objects” or “box with objects costing a great deal of money.”

In JHN 13:29 the physical money box is not in focus but rather the function performed by Judas. Therefore, for the literal phrase “Judas had the money box,” it may be useful to say simply “Judas was in charge of the money” (CEV) or “Judas was the treasurer for the group.” The Greek expression here may be understood as an idiom.

MAT 2:11: The Greek word thēsaurus, translated “treasures” by RSV here, may refer either to something valuable that is stored away or to the place or object in which something valuable is stored away. In this verse the translations are divided between the meaning “treasure” and “treasure container”; and even where the second of these interpretations is followed, commentators do not agree concerning the nature of the container. For example, some suggest “treasure box,” while others deny this meaning and argue for “sack.” In light of the many possibilities, none of which is conclusive, the best solution is simply to translate thēsaurus in a way that is most natural in the receptor language yet does not contradict the biblical culture. Some examples of things that contradict the biblical culture would be “suitcases,” “trunks,” and “safes.” These words should be avoided. Many translators have used general expressions such as “baggage” and “sacks [or, containers] they carried their valuable things in.”

Basket

5.18.2 Basket

References:

Hebrew אֵיפָה (’eyfah) EXO 16:36, LEV 5:11, LEV 6:13, LEV 19:36, NUM 5:15, NUM 28:5, DEU 25:14, DEU 25:14, DEU 25:15, JDG 6:19, RUT 2:17, 1SA 1:24, 1SA 17:17, PRO 20:10, PRO 20:10, ISA 5:10, EZK 45:10, EZK 45:11, EZK 45:11, EZK 45:13, EZK 45:13, EZK 45:24, EZK 45:24, EZK 45:24, EZK 46:5, EZK 46:5, EZK 46:7, EZK 46:7, EZK 46:7, EZK 46:11, EZK 46:11, EZK 46:11, EZK 46:14, AMO 8:5, MIC 6:10, ZEC 5:6, ZEC 5:7, ZEC 5:8, ZEC 5:9, ZEC 5:10

Hebrew דּוּד (dud, dudai) 2KI 10:7, PSA 81:7, JER 24:1, JER 24:2, JER 24:2

Hebrew טֶנָא (tene’) DEU 26:2, DEU 26:4, DEU 28:5, DEU 28:17

Hebrew כְּלוּב (kluv) JER 5:27, AMO 8:1, AMO 8:2

Hebrew סַל (sal, salsiloth) GEN 40:16, GEN 40:17, GEN 40:17, GEN 40:18, EXO 29:3, EXO 29:3, EXO 29:23, EXO 29:32, LEV 8:2, LEV 8:26, LEV 8:31, NUM 6:15, NUM 6:17, NUM 6:19, JDG 6:19

Hebrew תֵּבָה (tevah) EXO 2:3, EXO 2:5

Greek κόφινος (kofinos) MAT 14:20, MAT 16:9, MRK 6:43, MRK 8:19, LUK 9:17, JHN 6:13

Greek σαργάνη (sarganē) 2CO 11:33

Greek σπυρίς (spuris) MAT 15:37, MAT 16:10, MRK 8:8, MRK 8:20, ACT 9:25

Description and usage:

Description and usage:

Large woven basket for storing and transporting goods (© Habib M'henni, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The basket was a container made of woven material, usually grass or reeds. Baskets could vary widely in size, depending on their intended use. Baskets were used for carrying a great variety of things, including food and produce and even for moving soil from one place to another.

Translation:

The Hebrew word 'eyfah sometimes refers to a volume of measure and sometimes to the basket used to hold that measure. The translator will need to pay special attention to the context.

In ZEC 5:7 there is reference to something that serves as a lid or cover (kikar in Hebrew) for a basket. This object is said to be made of lead and does not seem to be a normal feature of a basket. Most translations render it "lid made of lead" (GNT) or "lead cover" (CEV, GW).

A basket with summer fruits (Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The Hebrew word kluv in JER 5:27 seems to refer to a very specialized type of basket, in fact, a cage for holding birds. RSV begins the verse with “Like a basket full of birds,” implying that the birds must be dead. However, instead of the word “basket,” most other translations prefer the word “cage,” which seems to sustain the imagery of the previous verse better. On the other hand, in AMO 8:1; AMO 8:2kluv is no doubt a general term for “receptacle.” The translation should have a general word if possible, one that would be appropriate for showing fruit for sale in the marketplace, carrying it, or storing it. If no kind of basket is suitable, then any container used for such purposes would be acceptable.

It is impossible to determine precisely the differences in meaning among the three New Testament terms for baskets listed above. In 2CO 11:33, which is the only place where the Greek word sarganē occurs, the basket was evidently rather large, since it was used to let Paul down from an opening in the wall of Damascus. The same basket is referred to in ACT 9:25 with the Greek word spuris.

Translators often find it difficult to find satisfactory equivalents for the Greek words spuris and kofinos, since in various receptor languages there are highly specific terms for particular kinds of baskets depending upon the type of construction and size. Unfortunately, there is no way of determining from the Greek text precisely the size or type of baskets involved. The translator should be careful not to use a word that indicates a container made of modern materials such as plastic or rubber.